GinCol Lab · Aula

Student worksheet

Artistic Drawing I · 1st year of Bachillerato · Learning to look · Class 3 of 5 · With Marina

Simple shapes and gaps

Class video: https://youtu.be/eDdaibkX8S4

The code leads to the video.

Name: _____ Date: _____

Before you start

Have a pencil, a sheet of paper, a pair of scissors and a piece of card (or the cardboard from a cereal box) to hand. Nothing else.

1. **One minute, without looking at the paper.** Hold your free hand in front of you, look at it and draw its outline very slowly, following the edge with your eyes, **without looking at the sheet even once**. It will come out strange: that doesn't matter. It is a warm-up for really looking.

2. **At the end of the class**, do the same with a mug or a glass, but now with its cross, its axis and its ellipses, and compare.

Simple shapes, step by step

A complicated object is blocked in with the solids underneath it: the **sphere**, the **cylinder**, the **cone** and the **box**. A solid carries its perspective inside it, and that is why it tells you where you are looking at it from.

1. **Squint.** The details disappear and the large shapes are left.

2. **The largest mass.** Before drawing it, measure its height against its width with the pencil. Draw it transparent, with that proportion.

3. **Its axis and its ellipses.** The axis passes through the centre of the ellipses and crosses them through their narrowest part, at right angles to the widest. A sphere on its own doesn't tell you which way it is facing: give it its axis and an ellipse around the middle.

4. **What is attached to it**, from large to small: each part, another solid (a low cylinder, a small ball, a cone, a bent tube), on the same axis if it shares it.

5. **Check** the proportion of the largest mass in your drawing with the pencil.

6. **The outline, on top**, and at the end you rub out the construction.

Ellipses. The further a circle is from your eye level, the more open its ellipse looks. At your eye level, it is a line. An ellipse has no points: it is round on both sides. First draw its cross (its width and its height) and measure how many times the height fits into the width.

Gaps, step by step

1. **Make a viewfinder.** In the card, cut out a window with the shape of your sheet: for example, 7 × 10 cm.

2. **Look through it with one eye, with your arm outstretched**, and move it until what you are going to draw touches the top and bottom edges of the window. The outer gaps are closed off by the frame.

3. **The frame is the edge of your sheet.** Whatever touches the edge of the window touches the edge of your sheet.

4. **The first gap.** Choose a closed one. Look at where it is inside the frame (for example, its top corner: at half the height, a little past half the width) and place it the same way on your sheet. Draw it as if it were a figure, without thinking about the object.

5. **Gap by gap**, like the pieces of a puzzle. Between one gap and the next there is always a piece of the object.

6. **Fill in the gaps** with a flat tone: the object jumps out at you.

7. **Check**: compare each gap in your drawing with the one in the model. If one doesn't look alike, something is wrong around it.

Drawing the gaps is useful, above all, for checking slants. Measurements, with the pencil.

While you watch the video

1. **Cézanne's letter.** What advice did Cézanne give Émile Bernard in April 1904?

2. **The glass.** Looking at a glass slightly from above, which looks rounder, the rim or the base? Why? What happens to the rim if you lower your eyes to its height?

3. **Two mistakes.** Why doesn't the base of a mug on the table look straight? What is wrong with an ellipse with points?

4. **The egg and the box.** In which of the two can you see which way it is facing? Why?

5. **The teapot.** What solids does it have underneath? What do you measure before drawing the body?

6. **One edge, two owners.** In the vase and the faces, whose is the line that separates them? Can you see both at once?

7. **The chair's triangle.** Does that triangle exist in the real chair? Which two pieces close it?

8. **Gaps and the pencil.** What are gaps useful for, above all? And what do you take measurements with?

Your mug, half done

The earthenware mug in the video (Met, 12.221). The board puts in its cylinder; you, the handle's gap.

	What you measure	What you get
The handle's gap: how many times does its width fit into its height?		

	What you measure	What you get
Where is it wider: at the top or at the bottom?		
What is its left side like, the mug's side?		
Check: does your gap look like the one in the model?		

The mistakes

Match each mistake with what it causes.

Mistake	What it causes
1. Drawing the mug's base straight	a. The body comes out whatever size it happens to be
2. Drawing the ellipse with points	b. The mug looks stuck to the table, seen from the side, not from above
3. Drawing the chair's rungs horizontal	c. A rim like a lemon
4. Starting with the details	d. The chair doesn't look like the one you see: in the photo, they rise or fall
5. Measuring with the gaps	e. Gaps are for slants; measurements, with the pencil

Practice

1. Choose three objects from your home (for example, a lamp, a bottle and a backpack, which is a box). Draw their solids, transparent, with their axis and their ellipses, and measure their height against their width.

2. With your viewfinder, draw only the gaps of a chair in your home, or of a bike, and fill them in.

3. **The silver teapot in the video** (Paul Revere Jr., around 1782, Met 69.147). What solids does it have underneath?

Keep thinking

Cézanne advised treating nature in terms of the cylinder, the sphere and the cone, and he wrote to Bernard: "I do not want to be right in theory, but in front of nature". If you reduce the world to simple shapes, you gain order. What is lost?

For the whole topic

A couple of pencils, an ordinary one (HB) and a soft one (2B or 4B), an eraser and some sheets of paper. Your drawings are yours: you don't need to show them or upload them anywhere.

The quotations are from Paul Cézanne (letters to Émile Bernard, 15 April and 25 July 1904), Émile Bernard (*L'Occident*, July 1904) and George B. Bridgman (*Constructive Anatomy*, 1920). The exercise with the chair and the viewfinder is by Betty Edwards (1979). The hand with the viewfinder and the student in profile are the channel's illustrations, made with AI. Cézanne's still life, the two teapots, the chair and the mug belong to the Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York, which releases them free of rights (CC0); Erhard Schön's plate (1538) too, from Wikimedia Commons.

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